wanting to be there. Of course, the supporter in me wanted to see England do well and I don't want to sound like I was just being selfish about it all. I can't pretend, though, that I wasn't completely devastated about being left out. I have a picture at home of me standing next to the dugout during the Tunisia game and the look on my face says it all: as if I'm about to throw up. I was that disappointed. And embarrassed, too: I felt like I'd failed somehow, and that I'd been shamed by the situation. The World Cup is the biggest thing any soccer player can ever be involved in and I found myself wishing that I wasn't there at all.

Not being in the team was bad enough. What really killed me was the supposed reason for me being dropped. Was I missing out here because I'd wanted to spend that day with Victoria? As if it was Glenn's, or anybody else's, business? Even people who might criticize the way I live my life away from soccer can see that, once I'm out there playing, nothing gets in the way of my concentration on the game. How could the manager have misjudged me so completely?

Our next match was against Romania and, because we'd beaten Tunisia, it would have been a surprise to be selected for it. I'd talked to Gary, to my dad and to Alex Ferguson about what had been happening and they'd all been supportive. All of them felt I hadn't been treated well. I also got the impression from back home that supporters wanted to see the younger players, like me and Michael Owen, given their chance. It gave me a real boost, when the two of us were warming up on the touchline against Romania, to hear the England fans chanting my name. As it happened, Paul Ince got injured after about half an hour and I went on in his place and played pretty well. So did Michael: he scored, even though we lost 2–1 to a goal right at the end.

I was happy to have got my World Cup started, proud that the supporters had cheered so loudly when I came on in that second game. But nothing was clear-cut at France 98. No sooner did I have the feeling that things were starting to go my way, I took another knock. Glenn Hoddle told the press that he had been planning for Michael Owen and I to play the third game, against Colombia, all along. He'd hoped we'd have qualified for the next round by then. It was like being told that you were a squad member who'd get a chance when the manager wanted to rest his first-choice players. Knowing I was going to play was great. Glenn's explanation as to why just left a bitter taste again.

At our base in La Baule, we had a small training field which didn't get